

Showing Causes

By any chance, did you see crowds marching on the streets waving banners, asking for the entire cricket team to be sacked? And effigies? Surely, there must have been effigies. There was said to be so much simmering "public anger" after India's lame-duck cricket in the World T20, that was the least we could expect.

Apart from hollering headlines and shrieking TV anchors, the only "public anger" that the Indians encountered was at Tequila Joe's in St Lucia from the worst kind of 'fan'—drunk, rich and loud. The kind who believe that the price of their ticket includes the right to demand victory in every game and the freedom to abuse when that does not happen. The best of India's fans are generous, supportive and fun-loving, but the St Lucia kind are fairly common place too. Cricketers get abused at home with words that in another country would have spectators ejected, tickets torn up by security. In St Lucia, these 'fans' did what bullies do. They went after the youngest, least experienced of the Indian players who were there at dinner, chatting with Kiwi and Aussie cricketers.

After Lalit-gate, the last thing Indian cricket needed was bad publicity. In the West Indies, they got it: not at Tequila Joe's but with their cricket on the field.

That's what the BCCI should be asking cricketers, selectors and management about, not an evening in a bar. The rest of the stuff is colourful, but immaterial. Sure, the immaterial does make for great story material but players don't play sloppy because they go out to eat—or even drink (unless it's Andrew Symonds on the morning of a match). They play sloppy because their fitness and time in the nets get sloppy. It is why the Indians were on the wrong foot at the World T20. Not the fact that they didn't stick to the 9:30 p.m. curfew because if one player is to be believed, there was no curfew. He asked, "Are we stupid not to go to bed on time the night before a game?"

It's best not to answer that one but in any case, you know what he means.

Maybe this image-conscious BCCI should also investigate where the information about coach Gary Kirsten's outburst at the team came from. Cricketers will hardly boast to the press about being less fit than a 42-year-old coach.

Kirsten also quarantines himself from the media with such determination that the Red Cross could take free advice from him about epidemic-prevention. If what is being said in his name is fiction, he would do well to issue a statement and stand by his team. Or rather, the team he wants India to be.

The St Lucia stool pigeon came from among the support staff in the room during that meeting. If the BCCI takes a headcount, it could easily identify the media-magnet. That's as much a cause that needs to be shown.



THE BAD PUBLICITY FOR TEAM INDIA CAME NOT FROM A NIGHT AT TEQUILA JOE'S BUT FROM THEIR CRICKET ON THE FIELD AT THE WORLD T20.



SAURABH SINGH/www.indiatodayimages.com

SIGNPOSTS

APPOINTED: Ratan Kumar Sinha as the director of the Bhabha Atomic Research Centre. He is closely associated with the design and development of India's first thorium-based Advanced Heavy Water Reactor.

TEST-FIRED: The nuclear-capable Agni-II missile successfully from the Wheeler Island off Orissa coast. The missile with 2,000-km plus range had failed twice in a row last year.

APPOINTED: Gita Gopinath, an Indian-origin associate professor at Harvard University's Department of Economics, as a full professor. She is the first Indian woman in the institution's history to be given this appointment.

WON: By wrestler Sushil Kumar, his first-ever gold medal in the Asian Wrestling Championship. He had won a bronze at the 2008 Beijing Olympics and is a



four-time Commonwealth Championship gold medallist.

WON: By India, the Sultan Azlan Shah Hockey Tournament jointly with Korea. This is the first time since its inception that two countries shared the cup.